Pork Birria Tacos

A bone-in pork shoulder is halved, seared in a Dutch oven, and braised in a brick-red adobo of guajillo, ancho, and árbol chiles warmed with cumin, clove, and cinnamon until the meat falls from the bone. The shredded pork is moistened with its own consommé, then griddled into corn tortillas with melted queso Oaxaca to make crisp quesabirria, served with the reserved consommé for dipping. Serves 6–8 (about 16–20 tacos).

Ingredients

Bone-in pork shoulder . . . . . 4 lbs.
Kosher salt and black pepper . as needed
Guajillo chiles 12
Ancho chiles 5
Árbol chiles 3
Water, for soaking chiles . . . . . 2 qts.
Tomatoes 3
Garlic cloves, crushed 6
White onion, chopped 1
Ground cumin . . . . . 2 tsp.
Mexican oregano . . . . . 2 tsp.
Black peppercorns . . . . . 1 tsp.
Whole cloves . . . . . 3/4 tsp.
Ground cinnamon . . . . . 1/4 tsp.
Kosher salt . . . . . 4 Tbsp.
White vinegar . . . . . 1/3 cup
Vegetable oil . . . . . 1/3 cup
Bay leaf 1
Corn tortillas 16–20
Queso Oaxaca, shredded . . . . . 2–3 cups
White onion, finely chopped . . . . . 1 cup
Fresh cilantro, chopped . . . . . 1 cup
Lime wedges . . . . . for serving

The Pork

Preheat oven to *325°F* — Trim hard fat and silver skin from **pork shoulder**; pat dry — Take **pork** out *30–45 minutes* ahead so it sears evenly

1. Cut the **pork shoulder** in half through the bone into two roughly equal pieces and season all over, generously, with **salt** and **black pepper**.
2. Heat 2 Tbsp. of the measured **oil** in a *6-quart Dutch oven* over medium-high heat until shimmering. Sear both **pork** halves, turning with tongs, until deeply browned on all sides, about *12–15 minutes* total. Transfer the **pork** to a plate. Make the adobo while the **pork** rests.

Birria Adobo

Stem, seed, and rinse **guajillo**, **ancho**, and **árbol chiles** — Crush **garlic** and roughly chop **onion**; combine in *Medium Bowl #1* (aromatics) — Combine 2 tsp. **cumin**, 2 tsp. **oregano**, 1 tsp. **peppercorns**, 3/4 tsp. **cloves**, and 1/4 tsp. **cinnamon** in *Small Bowl #1* (spices) — Measure 4 Tbsp. **salt** and 1/3 cup **vinegar**

1. Put the **chiles** in a large pot with 2 qts. cold **water**. Bring to a boil, covered, then turn off the heat and leave covered for *10 minutes*, until soft and pliable.
2. Meanwhile, boil the **tomatoes** in a separate saucepan of water for *3 minutes*, until the skins loosen and split. Drain and set aside in *Medium Bowl #2*.
3. Drain the **chiles**, saving the soaking liquid in *Large Bowl #1*—it carries flavor and adjusts the consommé later. Move the **chiles** to *Large Bowl #2*.
4. In a blender, combine the **chiles** (*Large Bowl #2*), **tomatoes** (*Medium Bowl #2*), **aromatics** (*Medium Bowl #1*), **spices** (*Small Bowl #1*), 4 Tbsp. **salt**, 1/3 cup **vinegar**, and 4 cups reserved **chile water** (*Large Bowl #1*). Blend smooth, about *1–2 minutes*, in batches if the jar is full.
5. Heat the remaining **oil** in the large pot over medium heat until shimmering. Add the blended adobo—stand back, it splatters—and the **bay leaf**. Cook, stirring often, for *20 minutes*, until it deepens in color and thickens slightly and a layer of red **chile fat** rises to the top. Taste, adjust **salt**, and turn off the heat.

Braise and Consommé

1. Return the **pork** halves to the *Dutch oven* and pour in the fried adobo until the meat is at least halfway submerged. Cover tightly with the lid and braise at *325°F* for *2½ to 3 hours*, turning the **pork** halfway, until fork-tender and the bone slips out cleanly (*195–203°F*).
2. Just before the **pork** is done, skim the red **chile fat** off the braising liquid into *Small Bowl #2*; this is the frying fat for the tortillas.
3. Transfer the **pork** to a cutting board. Loosen the braising liquid to a sippable consommé with reserved **chile water**, starting with 2 cups and adding more to taste, then strain through a fine-mesh sieve and keep warm.
4. Rest the **pork** *30 minutes*, then remove the bone and shred the meat into *Large Bowl #3*, discarding fat and gristle. Toss with about 1 cup of the warm consommé to moisten.

Quesabirria Tacos

Finely chop garnish **onion** and **cilantro**; combine in *Small Bowl #3* (garnish) — Cut **lime** into wedges

1. Heat a large skillet or comal over medium-high heat until hot but not smoking. Dip a **tortilla** in the **chile fat** (*Small Bowl #2*), coating both sides, and lay it in the pan.
2. Scatter on **queso Oaxaca**, then a portion of **pork**, then a spoonful of consommé. Fold the **tortilla** over with a spatula and press gently.
3. Cook for *2–3 minutes*, until the underside is crisp and deep red, then flip and cook *2–3 minutes* more, until both sides are crisp and the cheese melts. Repeat with the remaining **tortillas**.
4. Garnish with the **onion-cilantro** mixture (*Small Bowl #3*) and a squeeze of **lime**. Serve right away with bowls of warm consommé for dipping.

Equipment Required

- Dutch oven (at least 6-quart) with tight-fitting lid
- Large pot (at least 4-quart) for soaking chiles and frying the adobo
- Small saucepan for the tomatoes
- High-powered blender (at least 500 watts)
- Fine-mesh sieve or strainer
- Large (12-inch) skillet, comal, or griddle for the tacos
- Metal spatula and kitchen tongs
- Two forks for shredding
- Mixing bowls (small, medium, large)
- Sharp chef's knife and kitchen shears
- Cutting board
- Instant-read thermometer
- Ladle and small bowls for serving consommé

Hints and Notes

Yield

- Serves 6–8, making about 16–20 tacos with consommé for dipping.

Mise en Place

- **Small Bowl #1** — spices: 2 tsp. **cumin**, 2 tsp. **oregano**, 1 tsp. **peppercorns**, ¾ tsp. **cloves**, ¼ tsp. **cinnamon**
- **Small Bowl #2** — reserved **chile fat** skimmed from the braising liquid (for frying tortillas)
- **Small Bowl #3** — garnish: 1 cup finely chopped **onion** and 1 cup chopped **cilantro**
- **Medium Bowl #1** — aromatics: crushed **garlic** and chopped **onion**
- **Medium Bowl #2** — boiled **tomatoes**, set aside
- **Large Bowl #1** — reserved **chile water** (about 6 cups; 4 cups for the blender, the rest to adjust the consommé)
- **Large Bowl #2** — drained, softened **chiles**
- **Large Bowl #3** — shredded **pork** tossed with consommé
- Measure 4 Tbsp. **salt** and ⅓ cup **vinegar** for the blender; keep the **bay leaf** and ⅓ cup **oil** by the stove (2 Tbsp. for searing, the rest for frying the adobo)
- Take the **pork** out *30–45 minutes* ahead so it sears evenly

Ingredient Tips

- **Pork shoulder**: bone-in Boston butt delivers the most flavor and gelatin, and the bone slides free when the meat is done. Halving the shoulder before searing gives more browning surface and more even braising in the *Dutch oven*.
- **Chiles**: choose pliable, leathery pods that bend without cracking—brittle, dusty **chiles** are stale and turn bitter. **Guajillo** brings bright color, **ancho** sweet depth, and **árbol** the heat; pull one or two **árbol** for a milder batch.
- **Queso Oaxaca**: the traditional melting cheese for quesabirria—mild and stringy, it pulls into threads on the griddle. Asadero or Chihuahua melt similarly; mozzarella is an acceptable last resort.
- **Mexican oregano**: more citrusy and less minty than Mediterranean oregano, and the authentic choice here. If unavailable, use the same amount of Mediterranean oregano and accept a slightly sweeter herb note.
- **Corn tortillas**: thicker, fresh tortillas hold up best to dipping and griddling. Warm them briefly if they crack when folded.

Preparation Tips

- **Searing**: do not crowd the *Dutch oven*—sear one half at a time if needed so each side browns rather than steams. The fond left in the pot deepens the consommé.
- **Frying the adobo**: this step is not optional—raw blended chile tastes flat, and the tacos rely on the rendered fat. Keep the heat at medium and stir often; the sauce sputters as it cooks down.
- **Seasoning**: the adobo is salted at the blender and the **pork** is salted on its own, so taste after frying the adobo and again after loosening the consommé. Adjust gradually—it is easier to add than to correct.
- **Consommé consistency**: aim for a brothy, spoonable liquid you would happily sip, not a thick sauce. Add reserved **chile water** a little at a time; over-thinning dulls the flavor.
- **Griddling**: medium-high, not searing hot, or the tortilla scorches before the cheese melts. Lift an edge with the spatula to check for a crisp, deep-red underside before flipping.
- **Shredding**: keep the strands coarse so they hold texture in the taco and do not turn to paste when griddled.

Make Ahead & Storage

- The full braise improves overnight. Cool the **shredded pork** and consommé, refrigerate separately up to *4 days*, and skim the solidified **chile fat** from the chilled consommé to reuse for frying.
- Freeze **shredded pork** in consommé up to *3 months*; thaw overnight in the refrigerator.
- Griddle the tacos to order—reheated quesabirria loses its crisp edge.
- Reheat **pork** and consommé gently on the stovetop; loosen the consommé with a splash of water if it has thickened.

Serving Suggestions

- Serve quesabirria-style: crisp folded tacos alongside a bowl of hot consommé for dipping, with extra chopped **onion**, **cilantro**, and **lime**.
- Offer a salsa de árbol or salsa macha for those who want more heat.
- Round out the meal with refried beans, Mexican rice, or a simple cabbage slaw.
- Beverage pairing: a Mexican lager, a michelada, or hibiscus agua fresca to cut the richness.